Responding to Reviewer Comments

Zivich Research Group

Revise and Resubmit (R&R)

Nearly all the peer-review papers go through a ‘revise and resubmit‘ phase

- Receive reviewer comments from peers and have an opportunity to respond

This can be a difficult process, especially earlier on[1]

- Collection of some advice and practices

[1] I know of someone who says they celebrate when students post a preprint of their work, as the actual publication process can be stochastic and volatile

Receiving the Decisions

You get an email in your inbox that has the decision on a paper and comments. Here is what to do

- Share with your co-authors (or primary mentor) if they are not CC'd on the decision email
- Briefly read through the reviewer comments
- Unless you can adequately address them all in a couple hours, **wait at least a day** before revising the paper or drafting responses to the comments[2]

[2] Cannot emphasize this enough. Waiting a day will help you adhere to later pieces of advice

Advice – General

- Do **not** take the comments personally
  - This can be discouraging and emotionally draining. It gets easier as you do it more
  - Reviewer feedback is not a statement of your worth
- Wait at least a day before drafting responses
  - See previous point for why to take this time
- Start by drafting responses to each comment prior to actually editing the manuscript or materials. Here, we are developing a *strategy* for how to respond
  - That strategy should be agreed upon by key authors, if not all authors
  - Once that is agreed upon, then manuscript edits can take place

Advice – Response Document

- Copy comments (exactly as they are, including grammatical mistakes) into another document and use a number system for reviewers and their comments
- Always put any editor comments (and your responses) at the topic
- When finalizing the response document, note the location (line or page number) of that revision. Quoting the revised text may also be reasonable
  - Check the journal policies for how they want revisions

Advice – Writing Responses

- Be polite. Sometimes reviewers can be cranky,[3] but don't return the feeling. You are trying to convince the editor that your paper should be published. Mud-slinging with a reviewer does not help your case
- Be responsive. *As a rule of thumb*, you can only provide a push-back of 'no' to a single comment per reviewer. Some modification must be made otherwise
- Misunderstandings are on the author. If a reviewer does not understand something, then it is on us to make it clearer. In general, a peer-reviewer will read your paper more closely than any other of your future readers

[3] Remember how it feels dealing with a cranky reviewer when you are a peer-reviewer of other's work

Example

[redacted]

I thank the editor for the opportunity to revise my paper. Please see my responses to specific comments below. For ease of identifying the updates made, I have indicated my revisions in the paper using blue text.

Editor

E1: We would like to emphasize that a more specific title, avoiding "towards" and mentioning "causality", will be required to proceed with consideration.

Response: I have revised the title to "[redacted]"

Reviewer 1:

This is a very interesting paper presenting a causal-inference-based framework to bridge

Example

R1.2: The provided examples (tetanus vaccination, amlodipine & systolic blood pressure) are very helpful to illustrate the main concept. However, I was wondering if the author could also provide real-world examples (and published studies) for the main concepts (e.g. examples of concrete cases where models are vacuous or non-vacuous — or range of modeling results lying on the continuum between vacuous and non-vacuous models).

Response: I have added a published example of a non-vacuous model from the SARS-CoV-2 literature and described how it could be made vacuous.

"As an example of a non-vacuous model, consider the SARS-CoV-2 vaccination model of Padmanabhan et al. The chosen mathematical model structure restricts the mechanism of vaccination through an antibody response. For this model to become vacuous, the model structure would need to allow for vaccination to affect the outcome through pathways outside of the antibody response (e.g., cell-mediated immunity)."

Rejections

Sometimes you will receive a rejection

- Before resubmitting, you should consider any peer-review comments you receive
  - Do the response document drafting, as if you had gotten an R&R. Again, follow the wait a day rule
- Use that as a guide to whether modifications should be made
- Don't take it personal. Editors reject papers for a whole host of different reasons

Open Discussion

what is some advice you would give?